Alida Angafor

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Areas of specialization: Philosophy of cosmology, epistemology (self-locating belief), philosophy of mind and language (de se content), metaphysics of the self, philosophy of physics, philosophy of science

My work asks what it means to locate ourselves in the universe. Starting from David Lewis's account of centered worlds, I ask whether every belief is self-locating or only some, and what the answer means for anthropic reasoning in cosmology, where what our evidence supports depends on where and when we find ourselves as observers. I am especially interested in the reference class problem, which I take to be a question about what it is to be a subject.

EDUCATION

M.A., Philosophy · Central European University, Vienna, Austria · 2024–2026

- Thesis: "Understanding the First-Person Viewpoint from the Third: Some Remarks on Being Someone." Supervisor: Lisa Doerksen.
- The thesis argues that the subjectivity of experience, the fact that every experience is for someone, is grounded in a persisting subject rather than a self constituted only within momentary experience. Answering the centered-worlds objection, which treats whatever escapes an objective account of the world as a mere location, is what led to my current work on self-locating belief and the observer in cosmology.
- Graduate coursework: Beliefs and Desires and Advanced Epistemology (Katalin Farkas); Laws of Nature (Ferenc Huoranszki); Objectivity (Maria Kronfeldner); Epistemology (Phyllis Pearson).

B.A., Philosophy and Sociology, Minor in Astronomy · Dartmouth College, Hanover, NH · 2017–2021

- Astronomy minor coursework in mathematics, physics, and astronomy, which gave me grounding in the observational and physical science that philosophy of cosmology works with.
- Capstone project: *Knowledge Through Imagination*, supervised by Peter Lewis, a philosopher of physics.
- Relevant coursework: Realism vs. Anti-Realism (Amie Thomasson); Philosophy of Imagination (Amie Thomasson); Mind and Psychology (John Kulvicki); Research Methods.

PUBLICATIONS

- Angafor, Alida. 2026. "Understanding the First-Person Viewpoint from the Third: Some Remarks on Being Someone." M.A. thesis, Central European University. Available on PhilPapers.

WORKS IN PROGRESS

"Locating Ourselves in the Universe: Self-Locating Belief and Anthropic Reasoning"
PhD research project in development

- Asks whether every belief is self-locating, as David Lewis held, or only a special class, and uses anthropic reasoning in cosmology as the test. Compares the main accounts of self-locating content on fine-tuning arguments for a multiverse, typicality assumptions, and the rejection of theories dominated by random-fluctuation observers, and ends with the reference class problem as a question about what it takes to be a subject.

"Where Do We Go Between Experiences? Existential Subjectivity and the Self in Experience" Journal article in preparation, drawn from M.A. thesis

- Distinguishes existential subjectivity, the persisting subject that experience depends on, from experiential subjectivity, the self as it shows up within experience. Argues that a subject cannot be just its conscious experiences, and so gives an account of the persisting observer that self-locating reasoning in cosmology takes for granted.

"Misalignment as Evidence of Human Error, Not Machine Agency" · Independent research project, 2026

- Argues that attributions of agency to AI systems rest on Dennett's intentional stance, which cannot distinguish genuine from as-if agency, and that misalignment reflects human optimization choices and error rather than machine agency.

"Whose Lie Is It? Agency Attribution in AI Deception Evaluations" · Independent research project, 2026

- Argues that describing model outputs as deceptive rather than erroneous presupposes a thick notion of agency (belief, goal ownership, a first-person standpoint) that current evaluations assume but do not test. Includes a two-experiment protocol testing perspective invariance and goal ownership, bringing questions about the first-person perspective into empirical method.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant to Prof. Brad Skow · Department of Linguistics and Philosophy, MIT · Jan–Mar 2021

- Supported research in philosophy of science on how the sciences understand cause and effect, summarizing the relevant literature and presenting weekly on our progress.

Research Assistant to Prof. Maron Greenleaf · Department of Anthropology, Dartmouth College · 2021

- Produced a historical literature review on development, inclusion, and exclusion, tracing how a field's central concepts changed over time.

Human Development Research Fellow · John Sloan Dickey Center for International Understanding, Dartmouth College · 2018–2021

- Completed six terms of paid research assistantships on faculty-led, field-based projects aimed at alleviating poverty in low-income countries.

TEACHING

Astronomy Teaching Assistant · Appalachian Mountain Club, Bretton Woods, NH · Jun–Aug 2019

- Traveled hut to hut across the White Mountains giving public astronomy lectures and leading night observing sessions, explaining the structure and scale of the universe to general audiences, including children.

Teaching Assistant · Dartmouth Leadership Attitudes and Behaviors Program · Jan–Apr 2019

- Facilitated structured discussions on values and ethical reasoning in leadership.

ADDITIONAL AND PLANNED COURSEWORK

- PH 470: Philosophy of Physics, Boston University, Spring 2027 (planned)
- AST 0010: Wanderers in Space, Tufts University, Spring 2027 (planned)
- CS 2881R: AI Safety, Harvard University (Prof. Boaz Barak), external participant, Fall 2026

FELLOWSHIPS AND SCHOLARSHIPS

- Human Development Fellowship, John Sloan Dickey Center for International Understanding, Dartmouth College, 2018–2021
- Central European University Master's Scholarship (tuition and stipend), 2024–2026
- Dartmouth College Undergraduate Scholarship (partial tuition, room and board), 2017–2021
- Federal Pell Grant (partial tuition), 2017–2021
- Abramson Foundation Scholarship Award, 2017–2021
- Future Business Leaders of America Scholarship Award, 2017–2021
- Black Youth Achievement Award, Springbrook High School, 2014

GRANTS

- PLATO Grant for Philosophy Programs, 2017. Funded a philosophy essay competition I organized for peers at Columbia Heights Educational Campus.

SERVICE AND COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT

Judge, Judging Panel · Modus Ponens Institute (MPI Education) · 2026–present

- Judge student philosophy, ethics, and debate competitions for a philosophy education organization.

Therapist Understudy · Nashoba Learning Group, Massachusetts · Sep 2026–present

- Deliver one-to-one instruction based on applied behavior analysis to students with autism spectrum and related disorders, recording behavioral and skills data systematically to track each student's progress.

Child Welfare Caseworker · Chaffee County Department of Human Services, Salida, CO · Nov 2023–Aug 2024

- Made decisions about children's safety from evidence that was incomplete and still unfolding, weighing each person's account against what could be observed and documented.

Team Manager · Southwest Conservation Corps · Mar–Nov 2023

- Led conservation field crews through long seasons of outdoor project work, making steady decisions in changing conditions and holding the group together when the work was hard.

Field Staff · Elements Wilderness Therapy; Pacific Quest

- Lived and worked in the field alongside young people in wilderness therapy programs, supporting their daily routines and the therapeutic goals set by their clinical teams.

MEMBERSHIPS AND ORGANIZATIONS

- Minorities and Philosophy (MAP), Central European University chapter, member, 2024–2026
- Central European University Philosophy Club, member, 2024–2026
- Dartmouth College Philosophy Club, member, 2018–2021
- Columbia Heights Educational Campus Philosophy Club, founder, 2015–2017

SKILLS

- **Languages:** English (native), Spanish (conversational), German (elementary)
- **Programming:** Python, C++, HTML, CSS

REFERENCES

Available upon request